the beginning. The dots have joined into lines, even forming concentric circles of interest.

What then is the *mandala* that captures India's thinking of the world today? At its core is obviously the immediate neighbourhood, the objects of attention at Modi's oath-taking ceremony in 2014. The approach here is to begin by recognizing that India occupies a unique position in the Subcontinent by virtue of its size, location and, increasingly, economic weight. It is obviously in India's interest that its immediate periphery be stable, secure and sensitive. Ensuring this in a competitive world will require us to underwrite the larger region and invest in the connectivity, cooperation and contacts that make for a more cohesive geography. There are challenges from both history, sociology and economics to overcome in this pursuit. While they need to be managed, the heart of the Neighbourhood First policy is for India to convince its immediate neighbours of the benefits of closer ties and then proceed to make that happen on the ground. This is essentially what we have seen unfold since 2014.

Today, we are looking at a distinctly different picture, where trans-border transmission grids, fuel pipelines, roads, railways and waterways, and smooth border crossing have become the hallmark of our times. All this is underpinned by the usage of each other's capabilities, be it in goods movement, ports or power generation. It has allowed the entire region to benefit through larger scale and greater efficiency. The real test of Neighbourhood First came in Sri Lanka's economic crisis and India's expeditious response has done much to enhance the credibility of its stance.

The second circle of priority is the extended neighbourhood. In every direction, the Modi government has, by now, laid out an intricate plan of engagement. In the case of ASEAN and Pacific nations, the upgradation of cooperation is expressed in domains like security, development and digital. As a result, the Act East Policy not only deepens India's presence in Southeast Asia but also positions it as a launching pad to the Pacific region and beyond.

Towards the Gulf, the 'Link West' approach has seen an unprecedented intensification of activities in a range of areas. Ties with the UAE, in particular, have helped to accelerate the pace of progress. Obviously, India only stands to benefit as others seek to compete. From the days when our vision of the Gulf was limited to energy and labour, this now extends to